

Fair Trade has listed Kudumbasree as an unparalleled experiment in social equity, UK's City and Guilds Centre wants to collaborate with it, France's AREED follows its model and Kudumbasree is also being flooded by honours which include the UNDP award for best practice, CAPAM Gold Medal for International Innovation, UN's We the People Award and UNCHS's 100 Best Innovation Award.

In fact, Left governments may be out of favour, but they have led the way in terms of

the ubiquitous rickshawallahs an anachronism. The change is more dramatic further down in villages which are almost fully electrified with huge water tanks rising from among green fields. In Kishkinda and Baghila villages, reached through perfectly motorable roads, buffaloes have given way to huge Mahindra tractors. Says Mukti Pal, 42: "This tractor cost me over Rs 4 lakh but now I am assured that my land is ploughed faster and with greater efficiency. The banks are ready to give us loans and we have been good at paying back." Pal uses this tractor to transport goods which saves on costs and time.

Memari, which earns chiefly through rice and potatoes, has rice mills by the dozens and at least 13 cold storages for potatoes. Other innovations include investing in a modern Jaquard loom to replace the old hand driven instruments for the local weaver's society. "Our village nets around Rs 20 lakh annually from loom products and saris. The cold storage plants are another boon, attracting buyers from Andhra Pradesh, Orissa and even Bangladesh. There are enough cold storages to keep the produce fresh and farmers do not have to travel far to sell their produce," says Pal.

**Rural Schemes** Though local enterprise is a key factor, schemes like NREGA has undoubtedly made a huge difference to the rural economy and rural thinking. Two years ago, Shobha Bhardwaj, sarpanch of Aanwa village in Rajasthan, wanted to do something positive from the money sanctioned under NREGA. The village had a temporary rain water harvesting check dam. A little creativity boosted the storage capacity of the small lake below, and a plantation. Today, it is a popular picnic spot and a rare combination of eco-friendly tourism, apart from providing the villagers added income.

NREGA money is prompting grassroots leaders to think differently. Roads, power reforms, education, water harvesting and computer education have transformed Rajasthan's dusty, arid villages. Moreover, the new money has improved social conditions. Child widows have got employment under NREGA as well as plots of land. The Rs 1,500 given to mothers for institutional deliveries has improved the mortality rate of mother and child tremendously. The state's biggest gain has been through road links and power reforms.

The prime minister's rural road scheme



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State-sponsored loans allowed Pal to buy a tractor which has improved efficiency in tilling his land and provided him with transport for his produce. His family now has a fridge, a television set and other urban trappings and he plans to buy another tractor.

changing rural lives. Here's one panchayat office board in Memari in West Bengal that says it all. "In May 2009 alone, under NREGA, there was 100 per cent job utilisation with 745 applicants getting work." Since the beginning of the scheme in the end of 2005, a total of 2,926 job card applications had been received, of which 2,672 have been employed till date. Memari has slowly transformed itself from mud houses to pucca structures, and the population of 40,000 has access to three cinema halls, myriad restaurants, hotels, showrooms and above all, cash to flaunt. The busy Krishti Cinema hall crossing in the town not only has a small mall with a cyber cafe but the motorbikes zooming past make